

Hell hath no fury...



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Earlier last month, I woke up to a shocking announcement in my daily newsfeeds. In a blog post on Microsoft's OneDrive cloud storage service, they just rolled back an essential feature of their offering exactly a year after they first announced it – unlimited storage for paying customers, of which I was one. In fact the only reason hundreds of thousands like me gravitated towards Microsoft's OneDrive service was essentially that one feature.

To be fair, I should mention that the unlimited OneDrive storage feature also came with a monthly or yearly subscription of Microsoft Office 365 productivity suite. Still, for whatever reason, the company did break the promise it made to customers. The sea of backlash it received from users was evidence enough that the move wasn't well received by anyone.

Most were feeling a lot like me – shocked, angry, disappointed and sad. Shocked because my confidence in a technology company was irrevocably shaken, especially a company that introduced most of us to the personal computing era.

I was angry because I had paid money and felt violated. It was like signing a contract, paying for a service, only for the other party to turn around and say, “I changed my mind, I'm not doing it, and I'm not paying you back either!”

Most of all, I was disappointed in myself as I let myself be seduced, forgetting the simple rule that if something seems too good to be true, it probably is. What Microsoft was offering at the time fit this bill perfectly since it was vastly undercutting Google and Amazon's cloud storage offerings – like a mirage to a thirsty traveller in the desert, full of promise, but never delivering.

I chose Microsoft's Office 365 plan primarily for its unlimited OneDrive storage option, because of the simplicity it offered. I wanted to digitize, save and share a lot of my family's thousands of photos and videos dating back to the 1980s. What about others like me who flocked towards Microsoft's offerings with similar needs in mind? Microsoft seems to be making a habit out of shooting itself in the foot – remember the free Windows 10 upgrade

fiasco? How this OneDrive decision fits in with their “mobile first, cloud first” strategy is a mystery to me?

In an increasingly digital, tech-focused world, companies (technology ones especially) cannot afford to be so arbitrary. The reason Microsoft put forth for revoking OneDrive's unlimited storage cap was due to the actions of a small number of users who backed up their DVRs and movie collections, and ended up with over 75TB of data per account. Did they really abuse the system the same way Megaupload.com users did to be served with FBI takedowns? Even if they did, why should a large majority of users be held accountable to the alleged wrongdoings of a small minority?

Take Flipkart's Big Billion Day fiasco. Hype the living daylights out of a seminal offering, promise the moon and the stars to your customers and then, for whatever reasons, offer a substandard buying experience to paying customers. I know a lot of first-time online shoppers who got their fingers burnt on Big Billion Day who have gone back to never trusting online shopping again.

Microsoft and Flipkart are just examples, of course. The point I want to make is that of classic over-promising yet under-delivering business practices which have started to creep into tech-enabled companies. The biggest casualties in this whole affair turns out to be customer confidence and trust. But not for long. Payback is a *&^&% because hell hath no fury like a geek scorned! 

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